Benazir Bhutto blamed General Hamid Gul for the debacle and unceremoniously removed him from the post of ISI chief, replacing him with Lt General Shamsur Rahman Kallue, a retired army officer. But there was no change in the policies of either Pakistan or the US to dislodge the Najibullah government by force.

Around September-October 1989, R&AW officers armed with evidence of terror training camps confronted US officials, Ashfaq told me. The Americans were told that Pakistan was not preparing holy warriors for Afghanistan but terrorists who would haunt the Western powers in future. The Indian agents were rebuffed. A CIA note prepared on 13 November 1989 said the American intelligence community believed that the Afghan insurgents would prevail over time but continued USA support would be essential.

The Mujahideen are employing the right tactics—attacking lines of communications, airfields and trying to mount small scale military attacks throughout the country. The war may well continue several more years and there will be no significant changes in the military balance of power through this winter. Na-jibullah's Kabul regime survives because of massive Soviet support. It has surprised everyone by its military performance but remains unacceptable to the vast majority of Afghans. It is torn by factionalism and will not extend its control outside the urban areas. Certain of the important Mujahideen commanders must become more assertively engaged, particularly those in the north such as Ahmad Shah Massoud and Ismail Khan, to bring additional pressure to bear. A US disengagement at this point would be the worst possible alternative for US interests because this would cause the levels of fighting to immediately drop off, lowering